Chapter 7 · Story

Two teams stop sharing a table.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



When “we” takes over · c07s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

The shared checklist is unfinished. What is a useful first change?

A Agree on owners, deadlines, and needed support.

B Tell everyone their commitment is disappointing.

C Copy more people onto every task.

Suggested answer: A. Agreed owners, deadlines, and support make responsibility clearer and help people coordinate the work.

Who counts as our team?

- **Social identity**: groups help define who we are.
- An in-group is a group someone sees as us.
- **In-group favoritism**: favoring members of that group.
- Group preference can produce unequal treatment without explicit hatred.

Who counts as “our team”?

Repair volunteers



“Give our team first choice of shifts.” Group membership can shape preference.

Welcome volunteers



Their contribution can be overlooked. Favoritism can create unequal access without explicit hatred.

Check workload, incentives, and decision power. A shared name alone does not change those.

Make the shared goal workable.

- **Shared outcome**: a successful visitor experience.
- **Handover**: agree information, tools, and timing.
- **Participation**: share decisions, credit, and burdens.
- **Check**: a shared name alone does not change incentives or power.

One visitor experience needs both teams

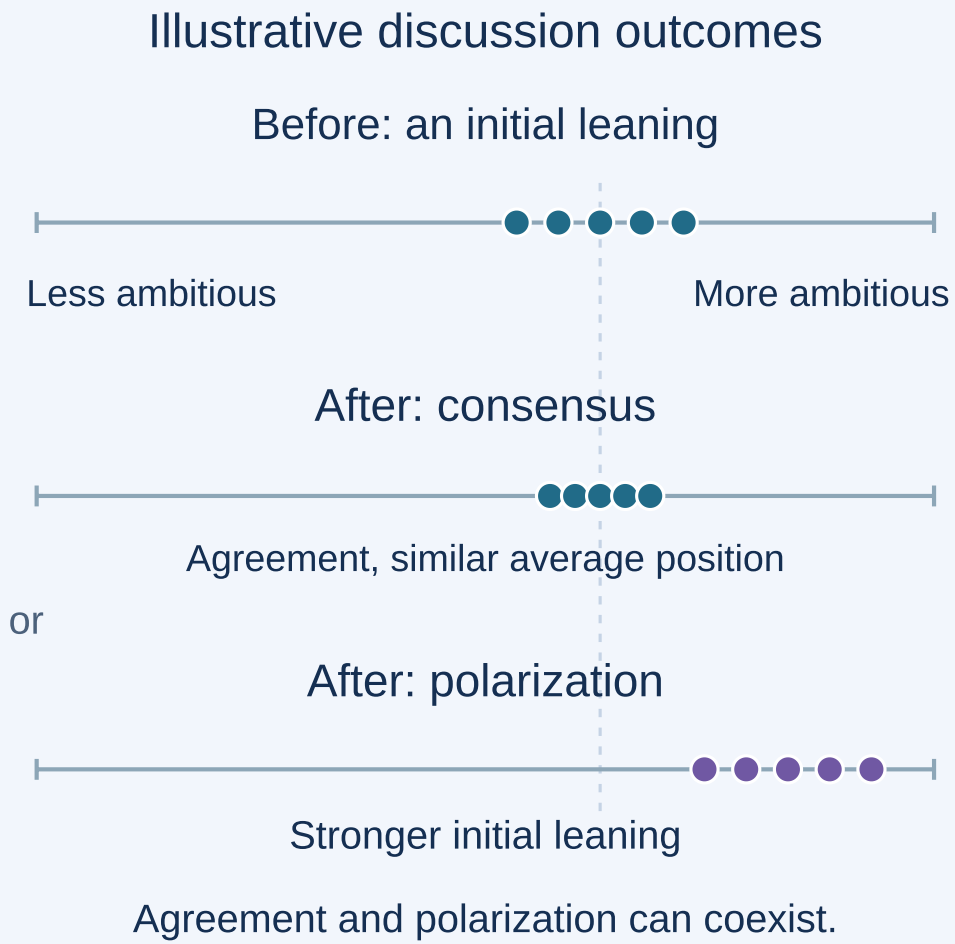
1. **Welcome the visitor**
   Understand the need
2. **Plan the repair**
   Agree roles and resources
3. **Coordinate the handover**
   Tools, timing, and information
4. **Review the visitor experience**
   Share credit, burdens, and decisions

A shared goal needs workable arrangements.

Shared identity needs coordination, resources, and decision rights.

Discussion can strengthen an initial leaning.

- **Group polarization**: discussion can intensify an initial leaning.
- The team may move from a small event to a week-long festival.
- Consensus means agreement; polarization concerns direction and extremity.
- Compare independent views before and after discussion.



Agreement can form with or without a more extreme leaning.

Poor output can have different causes.

- **Social loafing**: individual effort can fall in pooled work.
- **Coordination loss**: genuine effort is poorly combined.
- The unfinished checklist alone establishes neither process.
- Check effort, tools, sequencing, and roles.

Similar poor output, different processes

Social loafing



Individual effort
falls in pooled work.
“My contribution
will go unnoticed.”
A possible process.

Coordination loss



Effort can be high.
Work is duplicated.
A needed tool
arrives too late.
Tasks do not align.

An unfinished task alone does not identify either.
Check effort, tools, sequencing, and roles.

Different processes require different remedies.

What can we really conclude?

Groupthink describes cases where pressure for agreement interferes with critical discussion. A poor decision alone does not establish that this process occurred. To review the café’s planning meeting, look at what happened during the discussion. Which concerns were withheld? Which information was repeated or missed? Were roles or incentives unclear? Then choose a change that addresses the process you found. Independent estimates can broaden the evidence. Clear roles can improve coordination. Structured disagreement can make concerns easier to express. These changes help the team investigate the decision without pretending to know every member’s private thoughts.

Agreement can hide unspoken doubts

1. **Pressure for agreement**
   Relevant concerns remain unspoken
2. **Examine the actual process**
   Whose information was missed?
3. **Collect independent views**
   Make contrary evidence discussable
4. **Review the decision**
   Clear roles and structured disagreement

A poor decision alone does not establish groupthink.

Ask members about their concerns and check which information reached the discussion.

Try the idea somewhere new.

An event budget keeps escalating without checking demand. What helps?

A Ask members to show stronger enthusiasm.

B Gather independent estimates and contrary evidence.

C Open with the chair’s preferred budget.

Suggested answer: B. Independent estimates and contrary evidence give the group information beyond its existing enthusiasm.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does polarization differ from consensus?

> How can a willing group still perform poorly?

1. Consensus is agreement. Polarization is movement toward a more extreme position from an initial leaning.

2. A willing group can still lose output through poor sequencing, duplicated work, missing tools, or unclear roles.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a shared project you know well. Map each task, its owner, what must happen before it can start, and when progress will be checked. Identify one plausible obstacle and a check that could distinguish it from another explanation before proposing a remedy.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.